

SRK Academy of Music

Frequently Asked Questions

|| guru brahma guru vishnu guru devo maheshwara ||

The SRK Academy of Music, founded by Sri B. Sivaramakrishna Rao, offers one-on-one instruction in [Sitar](#), grounded in the traditions of the [Mian Achpal and Senia Gharana](#). This document addresses common questions from those considering learning the Sitar, and aims to help aspiring students and their families understand what this beautiful yet demanding journey entails.

I. For All Aspiring Students

1. What is Hindustani Classical Music?

[Hindustani Classical Music](#) is one of the two major traditions of Indian classical music, practiced primarily in North India. It is built upon the framework of [Ragas](#) (melodic frameworks) and [Talas](#) (rhythmic cycles). Unlike popular or film music, it is not composed of fixed songs — instead, it is a deeply improvisational art where a musician explores a Raga through structured phases such as *alaap* (slow, meditative exploration), *jod* (rhythmic development), *jhala* (fast-paced climax), and *gat* (composition set to rhythm). It is a living tradition passed down through centuries via the [Guru-Shishya Parampara](#) (teacher-student lineage).

2. How is Hindustani Classical Music different from Carnatic Classical Music?

While both Hindustani and Carnatic traditions share ancient roots in the Vedic musical heritage of India, they evolved into distinct systems over centuries. They differ significantly in their Ragas, ornamentation techniques, performance structures, and instruments. For example, Carnatic music uses *kritis* (fixed compositions) as the centerpiece of a performance, whereas Hindustani music places greater emphasis on the improvisational exploration of a Raga. The two traditions use different names for many Ragas, even when the scales are similar. They are not interchangeable — each is a vast and complete musical universe in itself.

Sri Sivaramakrishna Rao is among the rare musicians who has mastery over both idioms on the Sitar — but for students, the Academy focuses on systematic instruction in the Hindustani tradition.

3. What is a Sitar? How is it different from a Veena?

The Sitar is a plucked stringed instrument of the lute family, central to Hindustani Classical Music. It typically has 18–21 strings (including sympathetic strings that resonate in response to the main strings), movable curved metal frets, and a gourd resonator. Playing it requires pressing steel strings against the frets with the fingertips of the left hand while plucking with a wire plectrum (*mizrab*) worn on the right index finger.

The Veena (Saraswati Veena) is a different instrument associated primarily with Carnatic Classical Music. While both are stringed instruments, they differ fundamentally in construction, playing technique, tuning, and the musical tradition they serve. Learning one does not directly translate to the other.

4. How long does it take to learn Sitar?

This is perhaps the most important question, and the honest answer is: **many years**. Learning the Sitar is not like picking up a casual hobby — it is more akin to a lifelong discipline, similar in commitment to training in classical dance or martial arts.

With sincere, daily practice, a student may begin to play basic compositions within the first year. However, developing the ability to render a Raga with proper intonation, expression, and musical understanding takes several years of dedicated effort. Reaching a level where one can perform meaningfully can take a decade or more.

The beauty of this art lies in the journey itself — there is always more depth to discover, and even accomplished musicians continue learning throughout their lives.

5. How much daily practice is required?

For meaningful progress, a student should practice **at least two hours every day** — not occasionally, but consistently, seven days a week. This is the minimum. Many serious students practice considerably more.

Without regular daily practice, the fingers lose their conditioning, musical patterns do not become internalized, and the subtle ear for intonation does not develop. Irregular practice — even if enthusiastic during the sessions — does not lead to real progress. This is not a limitation of the teaching; it is simply the nature of the instrument and the art form.

6. What is a Mizrab? Will wearing it hurt?

A Mizrab is a small wire plectrum worn tightly on the index finger of the right hand, used to pluck the strings of the Sitar. It is an essential part of playing the instrument — without it, you cannot produce the correct tone or volume.

When first worn, the Mizrab will feel uncomfortable and may cause soreness or calluses near the first knuckle of the index finger. This is normal and temporary. Over time, the finger toughens and the Mizrab begins to feel like a natural extension of the hand. It should fit snugly — not so loose that it shifts during playing, and not so tight that it restricts circulation.

7. What will I learn in the classes?

Classes follow the traditional Guru-Shishya method. The curriculum progresses systematically through:

- Fundamentals — proper sitting posture, holding the instrument, tuning, and basic finger exercises (*paltas*)
- Introduction to Ragas — learning the grammar and aesthetic rules of each Raga
- Compositions — *gat* (rhythmic compositions), *sthayi* (main body), *antara* (upper register development)
- Improvisational techniques — *taans* (melodic runs), *sargam* (note patterns), *alaap* (slow exploration), *jod*, and *jhala*

Each lesson builds upon the previous one. Guruji will only teach new material once the student has demonstrated mastery of what was taught before — this is the time-tested traditional approach.

8. What Raga will I learn first?

Before learning any Raga, you will spend time on the fundamentals — proper sitting posture, holding the instrument correctly, tuning, basic right-hand strokes (*da* and *ra*), and finger exercises (*paltas*) that build strength, coordination, and familiarity with the fretboard.

The first Raga is typically [Raag Yaman](#) — a beautiful evening Raga that is widely considered the ideal starting point for students of Hindustani Classical Music. Its melodic structure allows beginners to develop a feel for Raga-based music in a way that is both accessible and musically rich. Guruji will determine the exact progression based on your readiness and pace.

9. What is the class format?

All classes are **one-on-one** (individual, not group), held once a week for approximately one hour. This personal attention ensures that teaching is tailored to each student's pace and abilities. Classes are conducted at Guruji's residence in Bangalore, in a room dedicated to music.

Online classes are also available for students who are based outside Bangalore or abroad.

10. What is the philosophy behind the teaching?

Sri Sivaramakrishna Rao teaches in the true spirit of the ancient Hindu [Darshana](#) — the philosophical tradition that sees art not merely as skill or entertainment, but as a path to inner transformation and the realization of the Divine through the beauty of sound ([Naada Brahma](#)).

He does not simply teach music as a technical craft. His intention is to uplift the student's life through the discipline, sensitivity, and awareness that this art cultivates. Students who approach this journey with sincerity often find that it transforms not just their musical abilities, but their relationship with themselves and the world.

This is not a commercial music school. Guruji teaches out of a genuine desire to preserve and pass on this sacred tradition. He is an acclaimed performing artist and composer — teaching is an offering, not a livelihood.

11. Do I need to buy a Sitar before starting?

No — and we strongly recommend that you do not buy a Sitar immediately. New students should attend classes for at least two to three months before purchasing their own instrument. This initial period allows you to experience the physical demands, understand whether you can commit to regular practice, and confirm that this is truly the path you wish to pursue.

Guruji has beginner-level Sitars that students may borrow or use before class. Students are welcome to come early and practice at his residence.

Buying a Sitar is itself a considered process — a good instrument is handcrafted and can take weeks or months to procure. Guruji will guide you on selecting the right instrument when the time is right.

A Sitar is a sacred instrument. It should be played regularly with respect and devotion. Purchasing one and leaving it unused is not something we encourage.

12. How should I choose the right Sitar when it is time to buy?

When you are ready, Guruji will advise you on selecting an instrument suited to your level and to the tradition he teaches. A few things to be aware of:

- Every quality Sitar is **handcrafted** by skilled instrument makers, often from families with generations of this craft. Each instrument is slightly unique. The best Sitars come from makers in [Kolkata](#) and [Miraj](#).
- There are two main styles of Sitar — **Kharaj Pancham** (associated with Pandit Ravi Shankar's tradition) and **Gandhar Pancham** (associated with Ustad Vilayat Khan's tradition). These are not interchangeable — different string counts, tuning, and playing approaches. Your Guru's tradition determines which style you will learn.
- Avoid very inexpensive instruments sold on general e-commerce platforms. These are often poorly constructed “decorative” Sitars that are unplayable and will actively hinder your learning.
- A good student-level Sitar is a meaningful investment. Guruji can connect you with trusted instrument makers.

The single most important rule: **always consult your Guru before purchasing**. He will ensure you get an instrument that is appropriate for your stage of learning and suited to the tradition.

13. What physical challenges should I be prepared for?

The Sitar is a physically demanding instrument, and it is important to be aware of this before beginning:

- **Finger pain** — pressing steel strings against metal frets will cause soreness, and in the early months, the fingertips of the left hand may develop cuts and calluses. This is completely normal and is part of the conditioning process. Over time, the fingers toughen and the pain subsides. Most beginners find that consistent daily practice builds adequate calluses within one to two months.
- **Sitting posture** — the Sitar is traditionally played while sitting cross-legged on the floor, with the instrument resting on the sole of the left foot. Extended practice in this position can cause numbness in the feet, stiffness in the legs, and back discomfort, especially for those unaccustomed to sitting on the floor. It can take several months for the body to fully adapt. Yoga and regular stretching complement Sitar practice well.
- **Hand and wrist strain** — the right hand wrist must learn a specific rotational motion for the Mizrab stroke, and the left hand must develop both strength and delicacy for pressing and bending strings. These can be tiring initially.

These are not reasons to be discouraged — they are simply realities to be prepared for. With patience and consistent practice, the body adapts. But it is wise to enter this journey with open eyes rather than be surprised later.

14. What does dedication look like for a Sitar student?

A dedicated student:

- Attends every weekly class without fail
- Practices at least two hours daily, every single day
- Comes to each class having thoroughly practiced and internalized what was taught the previous week
- Listens regularly to the great masters — developing the ear is as important as developing the fingers
- Approaches the learning with patience and humility, understanding that progress comes slowly but surely

Irregular attendance — coming for one week and then missing the next two or three — does not allow the student to progress, and it is a disservice to both the student's own aspiration and the Guru's time and energy.

15. What is the right reason to learn Sitar?

The most fruitful reason to learn the Sitar is a genuine love for the music and a desire for the inner discipline it cultivates. Students who approach this art with sincerity, curiosity, and patience — regardless of whether they aspire to perform publicly or simply wish to enrich their own lives — tend to thrive.

Learning the Sitar to gain quick visibility on social media, to appear on television programs, or to add a superficial credential is unlikely to lead to meaningful progress. The depth of this art reveals itself only to those who give it the time and earnestness it deserves. Shortcuts do not exist in classical music.

16. Can I learn Sitar from YouTube videos or online tutorials alone?

While YouTube and online resources are wonderful for listening to great masters and developing an appreciation for the music, **they are not a substitute for learning from a Guru**. The Sitar is an instrument where subtle details — hand positioning, the angle of the Mizrab stroke, the exact pressure needed for a clear meend (string bend), even the way you sit — make the difference between correct technique and habits that will hold you back for years.

A Guru observes, corrects, and guides in ways that a video cannot. He can hear when your intonation is slightly off, see when your posture needs adjustment, and know when you are ready for the next step. The Guru-Shishya tradition exists precisely because this art cannot be transmitted through recordings alone — it requires a living, breathing relationship between teacher and student.

Online tutorials can serve as a useful supplement alongside formal instruction, but they should never be the primary mode of learning.

17. I play guitar. Will my skills transfer to Sitar?

This is a common question, and the honest answer is: **very little transfers directly**. While both are stringed instruments, they differ fundamentally — the Sitar has 18–21 strings (compared to 6 on a guitar), uses a wire plectrum (Mizrab) rather than fingers or a pick, requires pressing strings against curved metal frets with bare fingertips, and is played while sitting cross-legged on the floor. The musical framework is entirely different — Ragas and Talas in place of scales and chords.

Your general musicality and discipline from guitar practice will certainly help — you already understand rhythm, have trained ears, and know what it means to practice regularly. But the physical technique and the musical system will all be new. Approach the Sitar as a fresh beginning, and you will progress well.

18. How do I care for and maintain my Sitar?

The Sitar is a delicate, handcrafted instrument that requires thoughtful care:

- **After every session** — wipe the strings with a dry cloth to remove sweat and oils that cause rust. Wipe down the body with a soft cloth.
- **Storage** — store upright with the head resting against a wall or corner, strings facing inward, gourd on the floor. The hollow neck has no truss rod — improper storage (such as hanging horizontally) can cause irreversible neck bowing. Keep the instrument in its case when not in use, especially in dry or air-conditioned environments.
- **Humidity** — wood and gourd are sensitive to humidity changes. Very dry conditions can cause cracking and tuning instability. A room humidifier helps in air-conditioned rooms.
- **Strings** — sympathetic strings (*taraf*) can break, especially in the early months. This is normal. Guruji will teach you how to replace them. The main playing strings should be changed periodically as they lose tonal quality.
- **Tuning** — the Sitar requires retuning before every practice session. Learning to tune by ear (with the aid of a [Tanpura](#) drone) is an essential skill that develops alongside your playing.
- **Frets** — the curved metal frets are tied with string and can occasionally need repositioning or retying. Guruji will guide you on this.

Treat your Sitar with the same reverence you would bring to your practice. It is not just a tool — it is a companion on your musical journey.

19. What are some common misconceptions about learning Sitar?

- **“It is like a fancy guitar.”** — The instruments differ fundamentally in construction, playing technique, tuning, and musical framework. Skills do not transfer directly between them.
- **“All Indian classical music is the same.”** — Hindustani and Carnatic are distinct traditions with different Ragas, techniques, instruments, and performance structures. See Question 2 above.
- **“I can learn it in a year or two.”** — Basic familiarity may come within a year, but meaningful musicianship takes many years of disciplined study. Even a lifetime is not enough to exhaust this art.
- **“Expensive decoration means a better instrument.”** — Ornamental work (inlays, carvings) has no bearing on sound quality. A modestly finished Sitar with excellent *jawari* (bridge work) will outperform a heavily decorated instrument with poor bridge work.
- **“You need Indian heritage or special talent to learn.”** — Anyone with dedication and sincerity can learn, regardless of cultural background. What matters is consistent practice and respect for the tradition.
- **“The Sitar is thousands of years old.”** — While Indian stringed instruments have ancient origins, the Sitar in its present form developed in the 18th–19th centuries. It is a refined evolution of earlier instruments.

II. For Parents Considering Sitar for Their Children

20. What is the ideal age to start learning Sitar?

While children as young as six have studied at the Academy, the journey becomes considerably more practical from around **age 13 onwards**. At this age, a student can typically:

- Hold and play a full-sized Sitar (smaller Sitaras are very difficult to find and build, and do not produce the same tonal quality)
- Sit cross-legged for the duration of a class without becoming restless or scared
- Travel to the class independently
- Take personal responsibility for daily practice
- Understand and follow instructions with focus

This does not mean younger children cannot begin — but the younger the child, the greater the responsibility on the parents to sustain the child's engagement, manage the physical challenges, and ensure consistent practice at home.

21. My child shows musical talent. Is Sitar right for them?

A child's natural inclination towards music is a wonderful gift. However, musical aptitude alone is not sufficient — the Sitar also demands physical capability (finger strength, hand coordination, adequate hand span for the fretboard), the temperament for patient and repetitive practice, and the ability to sit still for extended periods.

If your child genuinely enjoys listening to Indian classical music, shows curiosity about the Sitar specifically, and has the disposition for focused learning, this could be a deeply rewarding path. We recommend attending a few initial classes before making a long-term commitment, so both the child and the parents can make an informed decision.

Having a musical gift is a precious thing. But the responsibility of nurturing it is much greater than most parents anticipate. If you recognize this gift in your child, please be prepared for a long, demanding, and ultimately beautiful commitment.

22. What is the role of parents in a child's Sitar education?

The parents' role is crucial — arguably as important as the child's own effort. For younger children especially, parents must:

- Ensure the child practices daily without fail — this cannot be left to the child alone
- Create a quiet, supportive environment for practice at home
- Bring the child to every weekly class on time
- Be patient with the child's progress — resist the urge to compare with other activities where results come faster
- Not treat the Sitar as one of many extracurricular activities that can be dropped when schedules get busy

Nurturing a musically gifted child is a commitment from the entire family. The child will look to the parents for motivation during the inevitable difficult phases. If the parents' own enthusiasm wavers, the child's will too.

23. Will my child be able to play songs or perform within a year or two?

It is natural to hope for early results, but it is important to set realistic expectations. In the first year, a child will learn the foundational techniques — finger exercises, basic compositions, and the grammar of one or two Ragas. This is essential groundwork without which nothing meaningful can be built.

The ability to play a Raga with proper form and feeling, or to perform before an audience, comes much later — typically after several years of consistent practice. Expecting performance-readiness within a year or two can lead to frustration for both the child and the parents.

Think of it this way: a child learning Bharatanatyam or Kuchipudi would not be expected to give an *Arangetram* within two years of starting. The Sitar is no different — the foundational years are where the real work happens, even if the results are not yet visible on stage.

III. For Adult Beginners

24. Is it too late to start learning Sitar as an adult?

It is never too late. Adults who come to the Sitar with genuine interest often bring a maturity of listening, emotional depth, and discipline that serves them well. While the fingers may not be as supple as a child's initially, consistent practice overcomes this. Students have begun learning well into their fifties and beyond.

What matters far more than age is commitment. An adult who practices sincerely for two hours every day will make steady progress. The question is not whether you *can* learn — it is whether you are willing to give it the time it asks for.

25. I have a demanding career. Can I realistically manage?

This is an important question to reflect on honestly. Learning the Sitar requires two hours of practice every day — not when convenient, but every single day. It also requires attending the weekly class without interruption.

If your professional or personal life regularly prevents you from maintaining this schedule, it may be wise to wait for a phase in life when you can give this art the attention it requires. Starting and then stopping due to time constraints is disappointing for the student and does not honor the commitment that the Guru makes to each student.

That said, many working professionals do successfully learn music by treating their practice time as non-negotiable — the way one would treat exercise or meditation. If you can do that, you will find a way.

26. I want to learn for personal enrichment, not to become a performer. Is that welcome?

Absolutely. Not every student aspires to perform on stage, and that is perfectly fine. Many of the most devoted students of classical music learn it as a personal discipline — a way to deepen their inner life, cultivate focus, and experience the profound beauty of Raga music firsthand.

What Guruji looks for is not ambition but sincerity. Whether you wish to perform or simply wish to play for yourself, the only requirement is that you approach the learning with earnestness and discipline.

IV. For Students with Prior Musical Training

27. I already play another instrument or sing. Will that help?

Prior musical training — whether in vocal music, another instrument, or even a different musical tradition — can be a valuable foundation. An existing understanding of melody, rhythm, and musical structure will certainly help you grasp concepts more quickly.

However, playing the Sitar is a distinct physical and musical discipline. Regardless of prior experience, every student must learn the Sitar's specific technique from the ground up: the finger positioning, the *mizrab* stroke, the unique ornamentations (*meend*, *gamak*, *zamzama*), and the physical endurance required. There are no shortcuts through the foundational work.

28. Can I start at an advanced level if I already know music?

Guruji follows a systematic teaching methodology. Every student begins with the fundamentals of Sitar technique and progresses based on demonstrated ability. While your prior knowledge may allow you to progress through the early stages faster, you will not skip them — the foundations must be solid.

Progress in subsequent lessons is always determined by what you have demonstrated in practice, not by what you already know in theory or on another instrument. Guruji will assess your readiness and teach accordingly.

29. I know Carnatic music. How different is learning Hindustani on the Sitar?

While both traditions share a common ancestry, they are distinct systems with different Raga structures, ornamentation techniques, performance conventions, and aesthetic sensibilities. A background in Carnatic music will give you an excellent musical ear and a sense of discipline — both of which are tremendously helpful.

However, you will need to approach Hindustani music with fresh ears and an open mind. Some Carnatic habits may need to be unlearned or adapted. The Sitar itself demands entirely new physical skills. Consider it learning a related but distinct language — your existing fluency will help, but you are still a beginner in this new tongue.

30. I have trained in music. Should I expect the Guru to adapt his teaching pace to my level?

Guruji has a well-established and proven method of teaching. While he naturally tailors his instruction to each student's pace and ability, he will not make ad-hoc adjustments to the curriculum based on a student's background in other forms of music. Every student must earn their progress through demonstrated dedication on the Sitar.

It is also worth remembering that Sri Sivaramakrishna Rao is an acclaimed artist who has performed on the most prestigious stages in India and internationally. The opportunity to learn directly from a musician of his calibre is rare and precious. Students with prior training are encouraged to approach this relationship with the same humility and reverence as a complete beginner would — the Guru-Shishya bond is built on trust, respect, and patience.

V. Practical Information

31. Where are the classes held?

Classes are held at Guruji's residence in Shabhari Nagar, Bangalore, in a room dedicated to music. Students are expected to arrive on time and be ready for the session.

Online classes via video call are available for students based outside Bangalore or abroad. While in-person learning is ideal for the nuances of posture, hand positioning, and sound, online instruction has proven effective for dedicated students who do not have access to a qualified Guru locally.

32. How do I begin?

You are welcome to reach out through the [contact form on the website](#) or connect through the Academy's social media channels. Guruji is happy to meet prospective students and discuss whether this path is right for you.

We encourage you to attend a few initial classes before making a long-term decision. This will give you a firsthand understanding of the instrument, the teaching style, and the commitment involved.

33. Are there any resources I can explore beforehand?

Guruji has released two instructional DVDs — *Learn To Play Sitar* (Volume 1 & 2) — covering the history of the Sitar, types of instruments, tuning, basic lessons, fingering techniques, and concert patterns. These are an excellent way to familiarize yourself with the instrument before beginning formal lessons.

You are also encouraged to listen to the great Sitar masters — [Pandit Ravi Shankar](#), [Ustad Vilayat Khan](#), [Pandit Nikhil Banerjee](#) — to develop an ear for the depth and beauty of this music. Recordings are widely available on YouTube and streaming platforms. Listening is the first step of learning.

For further reading on the instrument and its traditions:

- [Sitar — Wikipedia](#)
- [Hindustani Classical Music — Wikipedia](#)
- [Raga — Wikipedia](#)
- [Guru-Shishya Tradition — Wikipedia](#)
- [Gharana — Wikipedia](#)

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